

movie industry as well. Neetu Chandra, 22, from Patna is vying for the 'bombshell' label after an uninhibited performance in the Priyadarshan-directed *Garam Masala* and a subtler showing in Madhur Bhandarkar's *Traffic Signal*. The former taekwondo expert, who believes in being 'hot, happening and guarded', hopes to make it bigger in Malayalam and Tamil films. Or perhaps she can even team up with fellow Bihari, Manish Tiwari, 34, from Muzaffarpur who has made his debut with a coming-of-age college campus film, *Dil Dosti Etc.* As his producer Prakash Jha puts it, "A large number of youth from the state are doing well in the electronic media and those undergoing training at the Film and Television Training Institute of India

was recently conferred the Legend of Regional Cinema award in the Netherlands. Mridul's films—*Sasura Bada Paisawala*, *Pyar Ke Bandhan*, *Bandhan Toota Na*, *Dehati Babu*, and *Dhartiputra*—are blockbusters while his music cassettes sell like hotcakes. Little surprise then that he features with Devgan in a soon-to-be-launched Bhojpuri production.

Another "star", Aishwarya, 19, from Muzaffarpur, recently launched his first album *Ek Main Aur Ek Tu* along with partner Ujjaini, who hails from Kolkata. Music company Saregama India released the album for the pair that had sung in the Bollywood hit *Corporate* and won accolades on Zee TV's *SaReGaMaPa: Ek*

from which a song *Chali, chali re patang...* was a massive hit. The song still captivates music buffs though Sinha rues that despite his talent, Chitragupta did not get the acclaim he deserved. Sinha himself rose from playing a villain to becoming the hero, challenging the might of well-entrenched film dynasties. Bajpai, who comes from Motihari, also Jha's birthplace, touched the psyche of the audience with his critically-acclaimed performances in *Satya* and *Shool*, while Suman has held on to his funnymen persona while pumping up his muscles in his mid-

RANJAN RAHI



▲ **MANOJ TIWARI 'MRIDUL', 37,** ACTOR, SINGER Has taken Bhojpuri films to an international platform

(FTII), Pune, are venturing into filmmaking. Not to mention the booming Bhojpuri film industry."

Jha is right. The Bhojpuri film and music industry that began its journey in 1961 with the movie *Ganga Maiya Tohe Piyari Charahi Bo*, has come a long way. It goes to its credit that superstar Amitabh Bachchan and Bollywood stars Ajay Devgan, Mithun Chakraborty and Nagma have featured in Bhojpuri films. Even celebrated choreographer Saroj Khan and music director Udit Narayan have flirted with it. The Bhojpuri exports are going places. Manoj Tiwari 'Mridul', 37, the globe-trotting Bhojpuri singer from Bhabhua district in central Bihar,

AISHWARYA, 19, SINGER On a high with a new album *Ek Main Aur Ek Tu*. Sang in film *Corporate*



Main Aur Ek Tu in 2005. It was melody and style that got them the audience's votes and the top position in the show.

The success of Sinha, Jha and Manoj Bajpai in Bollywood and Shekhar Suman on Indian television has propelled Bihar's GenerationNext to aspire for stardom. The unputdownable Sinha admits it in true Shotgun style, "I am and have been a great source of inspiration for the young in my state." Talking about his film city project, he says, "Our boys and girls are talented and ambitious but lack proper training. They have proven themselves many a times. Yet they lack confidence. The Film City will help them overcome this."

Not that Biharis in Bollywood are exactly new. Music director Chitragupta from Gopalganj district launched a film in the late '50s, *Bhabi*,

forties and carrying a tune.

It is respect and acclaim that the new breed of young Biharis is trying to win. When 18-year-old Deepali Kishore sang *Jab chaye mera jadoo...* during the *Indian Idol 3* contest little did she realise that she was rendering the theme song of an ambitious Bihar as it takes the great leap forward into showbiz. Deepali may not have won the contest but she gave a sterling performance, reaching the top ten, and has taken a break from Patna Women's College to do concerts for Sony BMG Music Entertainment in Mumbai. The world, it seems, is in her grasp.

Bihar may still be struggling to shed its feudal image but a young crop of aspirants is trying hard to give a fashionable makeover to the state.

with *Kimi Dangor* and *Kumar Harsh*